

How many trees were planted?

Checking government counts against the 100,000-tree pledge

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

“100,000 siġra fil-ħames snin li ġejjin”

Partit Laburista, 2022 manifesto, pledge 305

2024 annual count · end-2025 parliamentary answer · snap election 30 May 2026

VERDICT: LARGELY SUPPORTED

Counts confirmed; about 60,000 of the 100,000 by end-2025

Version 1.2 · 5 October 2026

Miżien · independent, science-first fact-checking

Draft for review · right of reply not sought (maintainer's direction)

MIŻIEN · AN INDEPENDENT FACT-CHECKING PROJECT

Contest a verdict, with evidence: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien/issues

TL;DR

Project Green reported more than 8,000 trees and more than 25,000 shrubs planted by government entities in 2024. The 2022 Labour manifesto separately pledged 100,000 trees over five years. In February 2026, the Environment Minister told Parliament that relevant government entities had planted around 60,000 trees and over 100,000 shrubs through the end of 2025.

Counts confirmed; the 100,000 trees were not reached by the end of 2025, and no later count shows them reached before the legislature ended. The official figures support the stated planting totals, but they are not a surviving-tree count. The roughly 60,000 trees equal about 60% of the pledge at the end-2025 checkpoint, when about three-quarters of the five-year period had passed; Labour's own 2026 manifesto gives a lower figure, more than 57,000. The legislature ended with a snap general election on 30 May 2026. The record does not show that tree canopy increased.

- 1

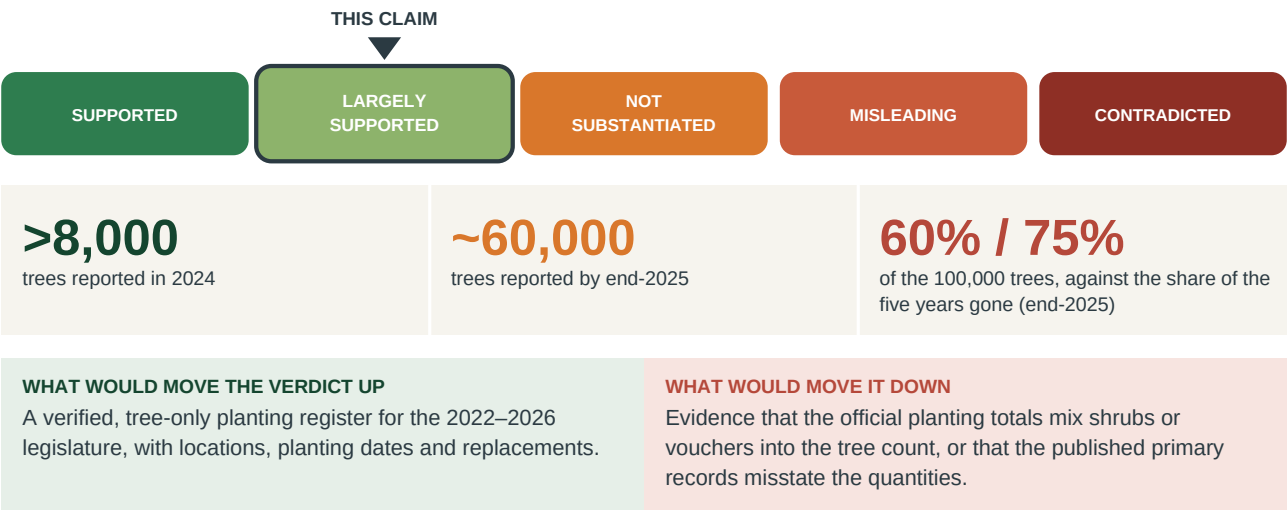
The 2024 figures are distinct. Project Green reported over 8,000 trees and over 25,000 shrubs. Shrubs are not trees and are not added to the manifesto target.
- 2

The pledge is real and time-bound. Pledge 305 in the Labour manifesto committed to 100,000 trees in the next five years, from March 2022. The legislature ended early, with a snap general election on 30 May 2026.
- 3

The latest official progress figure is partial. A parliamentary answer reports around 60,000 trees and over 100,000 shrubs by end-2025. It gives no project-level inventory. Labour's 2026 manifesto reports more than 57,000 trees for 2022–2025.
- 4

Delivery of the pledge is not substantiated. It is rated separately: about 60% of the trees by end-2025, with 75% of the time gone, and no later count. The verdict on the counts is unchanged.
- 5

Planting is not survival. Neither source provides a survival rate or a national cohort inventory; Mediterranean field studies show survival depends on species, site and method.



IN THIS REPORT	
1 What was said	4 Testing the claim, verdict and limits
2 Checking the counts	5 Sources
3 What planting totals measure	

1

What was said

On 31 December 2024, Project Green reported that more than 8,000 trees had been planted during the year through projects coordinated by entities under the Environment Ministry, and separately that more than 25,000 shrubs had been planted by government entities [1]. The release names Project Green, Ambjent Malta, ERA and GreenServ. These are government-reported totals; the release does not publish a site-by-site list.

THE PLEDGE

Pledge 305 of Partit Laburista's 2022 manifesto commits to an action plan for tree planting and afforestation and to 100,000 trees being planted “fil-ħames snin li ġejjin” — in the next five years [2]. The manifesto was published in March 2022, ahead of the general election of 26 March 2022, so five years would run to March 2027. The legislature ended earlier: a snap general election was held on 30 May 2026 [8].

In a written answer to Parliamentary Question 34270, the Environment Minister said that, through the end of 2025, entities under her Ministry and entities under other ministries had together planted around 60,000 trees and more than 100,000 shrubs during the legislature [3]. The answer is broader than Project Green alone and does not break the counts down by agency or project.

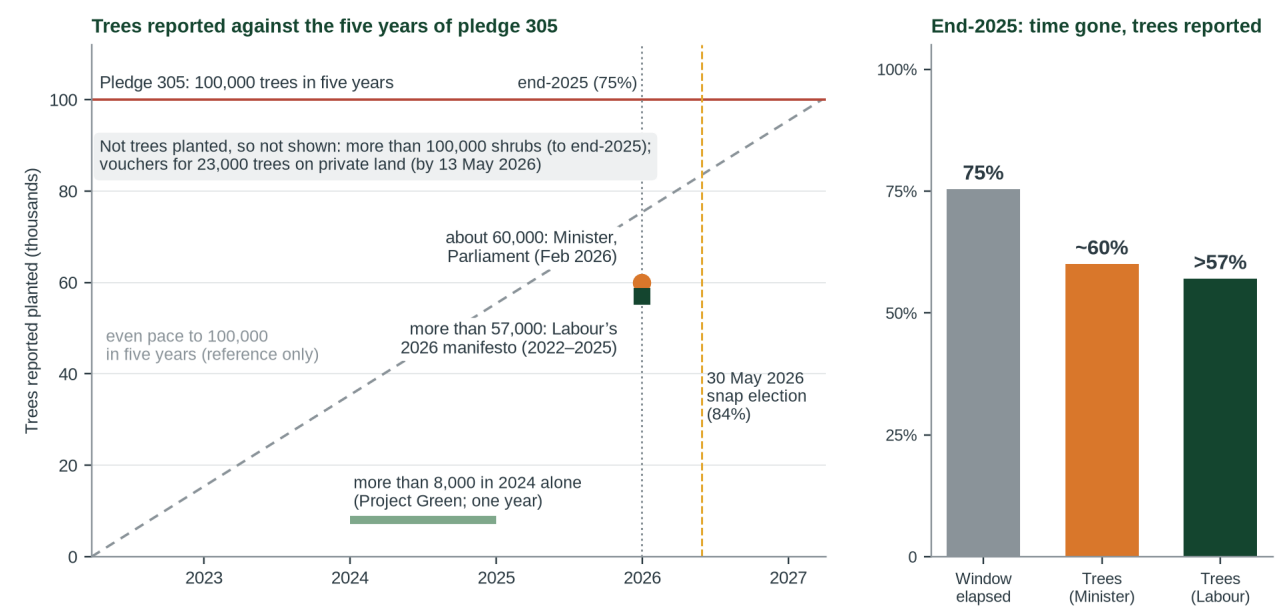
Labour's 2026 election manifesto gives the party's own count: “Bejn l-2022 u l-2025 thawlu aktar minn 57,000 siġra” — between 2022 and 2025, more than 57,000 trees were planted [9]. That is lower than the Minister's figure of around 60,000 for a similar period. Both figures are approximate, and neither document reconciles them.

The two annual/cumulative statements have different periods and scopes. Do not add the 2024 count to the cumulative 60,000, or add shrubs to either tree figure. The separate private-land voucher scheme announced in 2025–26 is also not counted here: by 13 May 2026, Project Green reported vouchers issued for 23,000 trees to more than 250 beneficiaries, some of them already redeemed [4, 10]. Vouchers issued are not trees planted.

2 Checking the counts

The calculation in `data/cc-010/calc.py` divides the Minister's approximate end-2025 tree figure by the manifesto target, and computes the share of the five-year period elapsed from the dates in `data/cc-010/dates.csv`. It does not assume a straight-line planting schedule or treat the arithmetic balance as a final shortfall.

Record	Trees	Shrubs	Interpretation
Project Green, 2024	>8,000	>25,000	Reported annual planting; government entities.
Parliamentary answer, through 2025	about 60,000	>100,000	Collective figure across relevant ministries.
Labour manifesto, 2026	more than 57,000	—	Party's own count for 2022–2025; lower than the Minister's.
Labour manifesto, 2022	100,000 target	—	Planting commitment over the next five years.



Window counted from the 26 March 2022 election. Shrubs (more than 25,000 in 2024) and vouchers (a separate private-land scheme) are reported separately from trees. Sources: Project Green (31 Dec 2024; 13 May 2026); Parliament, PQ 34270 (18 Feb 2026); Partit Laburista manifestos 2022 (pledge 305) and 2026 (item 43); IFES ElectionGuide.

Figure 1. Left: trees reported against the five years of pledge 305, counted from the 26 March 2022 election; the dashed line is an even pace to 100,000, for reference only. Right: at the end of 2025, 75% of the window had passed and about 60% of the trees had been reported (more than 57% on Labour's count). Shrubs and vouchers are not trees planted and are kept out [1–4, 8–10].

The figures are approximate and stop at the end of 2025. A rounded 60,000 is about 60% of the 100,000 pledge; subtracting it leaves about 40,000 trees. Counted from the general election of 26 March 2022, about 75% of the five-year period had passed by the end of 2025, and about 84% by the snap election of 30 May 2026, which ended the legislature [8]. No later count was found: Project Green's news from the election to 5 October 2026 reports gardens and open spaces but no tree total, and Parliament's website could not be searched by script. The arithmetic is therefore a checkpoint. It does not show delivery, which is rated not substantiated in Section 4, and it does not prove a final shortfall either.

Do the published planting totals show that the pledge has been delivered?		NOT SUBSTANTIATED
EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION The Minister reported around 60,000 trees planted collectively through the end of 2025, and Project Green separately reported more than 8,000 trees planted in 2024 [1, 3].	EVIDENCE AGAINST The reported cumulative count is below 100,000 and approximate. It stops at the end of 2025, five months before the 30 May 2026 election ended the legislature; no 2026 total or reconciliation to pledge 305 was located [2, 3, 8].	
WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE The count establishes interim reported progress, not delivery of 100,000 trees within the legislature; nor does it prove a final shortfall.		

3

What planting totals measure

The government records describe numbers planted. They do not report how many trees were alive after establishment, how many were replaced, or how much canopy they produced. Ambjent Malta's 2024 report gives a more detailed but still partial example: it reports 7,380 trees and 13,970 shrubs planted in 2024, and separately 3,209 trees and shrubs in Natura 2000 sites [5]. The protected-site figure is a subset and combines trees with shrubs; it is not a national tree-only total.

Peer-reviewed Mediterranean research shows why a planting count cannot stand in for survival. A 20-year *Pinus halepensis* experiment in arid south-eastern Spain found survival differed substantially among shelter treatments; after 20 years, reported survival ranged from 29.5% to 57.5% [6]. A southern Spanish restoration study also found different three-year survival under nurse-based and traditional planting methods [7]. These are evidence that site and method matter, not survival estimates for Malta or for the Government's cohorts.

WHAT A VERIFIABLE OUTCOME RECORD NEEDS
For each planting cohort: project and location; species; number planted; planting date; maintenance and replacement; repeated survival checks; and, where the aim is greener public space, measured canopy or habitat change. The sources located for this check do not provide a national linked record of that kind.

The EU's MapMyTree register and satellite canopy data could provide separate context, but neither can by itself verify these national programme totals or survival without matched locations and definitions. No such reconciliation is attempted here.

4

Testing the claim, verdict and limits

Sub-claim	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. More than 8,000 trees and more than 25,000 shrubs planted by government entities in 2024	Stated in Project Green's release [1]; self-reported, with no site list.	SUPPORTED
B. Pledge 305: 100,000 trees in the next five years	Wording confirmed in the 2022 manifesto, PDF p. 91 [2].	SUPPORTED
C. About 60,000 trees and more than 100,000 shrubs planted through end-2025	Stated by the Minister in Parliament [3]; rounded, no project list; Labour's own count is lower, more than 57,000 [9].	LARGELY SUPPORTED
D. Delivery of 100,000 trees within the pledge period	About 60,000 (Labour: more than 57,000) by end-2025, when about 75% of the window had elapsed; the legislature then ended with the 30 May 2026 election, and no later count was found [3, 8, 9].	NOT SUBSTANTIATED

The verdict applies to the reported counts, sub-claims A to C, which is the claim as stated. The pledge's delivery, sub-claim D, is rated separately and does not change it.

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

Counts confirmed; the 100,000 trees were not reached by end-2025 (about 60,000), and no later count was found before the legislature ended. Confidence: moderate.

Primary records confirm Project Green's 2024 statement of more than 8,000 trees and more than 25,000 shrubs, the 100,000-tree pledge in the 2022 Labour manifesto, and the Minister's approximate cumulative count of around 60,000 trees and more than 100,000 shrubs through end-2025 (Labour's 2026 manifesto gives more than 57,000 trees for 2022–2025). Confidence is moderate because totals are self-reported, rounded and lack a published project-level inventory.

The pledge is rated separately: delivery of 100,000 trees within the pledge period is not substantiated. The latest cumulative count stops at the end of 2025, when about three-quarters of the five-year period had passed and about 60% of the trees had been reported; the legislature then ended with the snap election of 30 May 2026, and no later count was found. Without a final count this is not proof of a shortfall either. The records do not establish survival, net canopy gain or habitat recovery. The Project Green 2024 and parliamentary figures have different scopes and must not be added together.

Evidence needed to settle delivery and outcomes

- ☐ Publish a tree-only, project-level register for the 2022–2026 legislature, including dates, locations, species and responsible entity.
- ☐ State whether the 100,000 commitment includes trees planted by other ministries, contractors, private landowners or replacement planting.
- ☐ Report cohort survival and replacements at comparable intervals; distinguish shrubs and vouchers from planted trees.
- ☐ Where increased tree cover is the aim, publish comparable canopy measurements rather than using planting totals as a proxy.

Right of reply. Not sought in this draft, at the maintainer's direction.

5

Sources

- [1] Project Green, 'Over 8,000 new trees in 2024', 31 December 2024. <https://projectgreen.mt/over-8000-new-trees-in-2024/>
- [2] Partit Laburista, Malta Flimkien: Manifest Elettorali 2022, pledge 305, printed p. 89 (PDF p. 91). <https://talk.mt/wp-content/uploads/2022/03/MALTA-FLIMKIEN-MANIFEST-ELETTORALI-2022.pdf>
- [3] House of Representatives of Malta, Parliamentary Question 34270, sitting 435, 18 February 2026, p. 25. https://www.parlament.mt/media/137706/20260218_435o_par.pdf
- [4] Ministry for the Environment, 'Distribution of trees begins to the first beneficiaries of the tree-planting initiative', 15 April 2026. Separate private-land scheme. <https://www.gov.mt/en/Government/DOI/Press%20Releases/Pages/2026/04/15/PR260616en.aspx>
- [5] Ambjent Malta, Annual Report 2024, pp. 49–51. <https://parlament.mt/media/136607/06228.pdf>
- [6] Olliet et al., *Frontiers in Forests and Global Change* 5 (2023), doi:10.3389/ffgc.2022.1092703. <https://doi.org/10.3389/ffgc.2022.1092703>
- [7] Rey et al., *Journal of Applied Ecology* 46(4) (2009): 937–945, doi:10.1111/j.1365-2664.2009.01680.x. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1365-2664.2009.01680.x>
- [8] IFES ElectionGuide, Malta: Maltese House of Representatives 2026 General (held 30 May 2026; previous election 26 March 2022; results source: Electoral Commission of Malta). Accessed 5 October 2026. <https://electionguide.org/elections/id/5161/>
- [9] Partit Laburista, Int Malta: Manifest Elettorali 2026, item 43, printed p. 168 (PDF p. 170). https://partitlaburista.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/08/Manifest_Elettorali_INT_MALTA_2026.pdf
- [10] Project Green, 'Vouchers continue to be issued to beneficiaries of the Tree Planting Initiative', 13 May 2026. <https://projectgreen.mt/vouchers-continue-to-be-issued-to-beneficiaries-of-the-tree-planting-initiative/>

Version 1.2 · 5 October 2026 · Right of reply not sought · Calculations: <data/cc-010/checks.csv>

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	3 Oct 2026	First issue. Right of reply not sought, at the maintainer's direction.
1.1	5 Oct 2026	Corrections: the pledge was framed as open until 2027; it now records that the legislature ended with the snap general election of 30 May 2026 [8] and that about 75% of the five-year period had passed by end-2025, against about 60% of the trees reported (the "2027 deadline" tile is replaced). Added Labour's own 2026 manifesto count, more than 57,000 trees for 2022–2025 [9], alongside the Minister's ~60,000. Updated the voucher scheme to 23,000 trees in vouchers issued by 13 May 2026 [10]; vouchers are not trees planted. Cover note shortened to fit; italics fixed. Verdict and confidence unchanged.
1.2	5 Oct 2026	Upgrade: (1) New Figure 1, trees reported (more than 8,000 in 2024; about 60,000 and more than 57,000 by end-2025) against the five-year window of pledge 305 (75% elapsed by end-2025; the 30 May 2026 election at 84%), with shrubs and vouchers kept out; it replaces the Section 2 tiles. (2) Searched for a count after the 30 May 2026 election (Project Green's news to 5 October 2026; web searches): none found. (3) New sub-claim table in Section 4 (A–D); TL;DR, a tile, verdict box, cover note, flyer and claim.yml updated. Version and date added to the cover. Cover, page footer and flyer: "pending right of reply" → "right of reply not sought", matching the text.
1.2	5 Oct 2026	Maintainer decision (5 Oct 2026): pledge delivery rated separately as Not substantiated; overall verdict unchanged.